

The Northern Australia Biosecurity Framework Reference provides strategic advice on, and support for, a collaborative approach to the delivery of biosecurity in northern Australia. It builds on and supersedes the Northern Australia Quarantine Strategy (NAQS) Steering Committee.

The Reference Group identifies common biosecurity delivery priorities across governments and agricultural industries to help ensure that the Australian Government biosecurity surveillance effort for northern Australia is appropriately targeted to risk, and effectively aligned with other stakeholder effort.

In March 2019, the Reference Group endorsed the development of a Northern Australia Biosecurity Strategy.

Members of the Reference Group include:

- Department of Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry:
 - Deputy Secretary (co-chair)
 - FAS, Biosecurity Operations Division
 - FAS, Biosecurity Plant and Science Services Division
 - FAS, Biosecurity Animal Division
 - Chief Environmental Biosecurity Officer
 - AS, Science and Surveillance Group
 - AS, Biosecurity Strategy and Reform Group
- Queensland, Chief Biosecurity Officer & Deputy D-G, Biosecurity Queensland
- Western Australia, Executive Director Biosecurity, Department of Primary Industries and Regional Development
- Northern Territory, Executive Director Biosecurity, Department of Industry, Tourism and Trade (co-chair)
- National Indigenous Australians Agency, Branch Manager, Economic Policy & Programs
- Plant Health Australia, CEO
- Animal Health Australia, CEO

The fourteenth meeting of the Northern Australia Biosecurity Framework Reference Group took place on Wednesday, 2 October 2024 by videoconference.

The Reference Group received updates on various initiatives including the Northern Australia Biosecurity Strategy, the Northern Australia People Capacity and Response Network and the Northern Australia Coordination Network. ARTD Consultants outlined findings and recommendations from an independent evaluation of progress to date to implement the Northern Australia Biosecurity Strategy. Both the Chief Veterinary Officer and the Chief Environmental Biosecurity Officer provided updates from their respective program areas and jurisdictional updates were received. The Reference Group endorsed proposals to extend the Terms of Reference until 31 December 2025 and for a Northern Australia People Capacity and Response Network First Nations Board Intern to attend Reference Group meetings for the next year. The Co-Chairs agreed to meet out of session to review the structure and priorities for future Reference Group meetings.

It is anticipated that the Reference Group will next meet in the first quarter of 2025.

The thirteenth meeting of the Northern Australia Biosecurity Framework Reference Group took place on Tuesday, 5 September 2023 by videoconference.

The Reference Group received updates on various initiatives under the Northern Australia Biosecurity Strategy, including the Northern Australia People Capacity and Response Network and Northern Australia Coordination Network, as well as the Catalysing Australia's Biosecurity Program. The Reference Group emphasised the value of cross-jurisdiction collaboration to maximise outcomes for initiatives in northern Australia.

It is anticipated that the Reference Group will next meet in the second quarter of 2024.

The twelfth meeting of the Northern Australia Biosecurity Framework Reference Group took place on Thursday 1 December 2022 by videoconference.

The Reference Group reviewed and discussed its current priorities and shared updates on revised funding for biosecurity in northern Australia (including the Australian Government's \$11M for the implementation of the Northern Australia Biosecurity Strategy). Funding for the Northern Australia Biosecurity Strategy will be focussed on priority initiatives including capacity and capability uplift across:

- stakeholder engagement,
- preparedness and response,
- diagnostics and surveillance capability,
- improved data and information sharing, and
- implementation of relevant biosecurity technologies and research.

The Reference Group supported the pursuit of opportunities to collaborate with complementary initiatives across the research, industry, state and territory, and federal sectors (such as the Northern Australia Coordination Network and the National Biosecurity Strategy) to maximise the investment of resources and funds. The Reference Group will next meet in the second quarter of 2023.

The eleventh meeting of the Northern Australia Biosecurity Framework Reference Group took place on Thursday 12 May 2022 by videoconference.

The Reference Group discussed current disease incursions and preparedness activities relevant to northern Australia, including Japanese encephalitis, and the detection of foot-and-mouth disease and lumpy skin disease in Indonesia.

The Reference Group agreed to formally review governance arrangements for the recently announced \$61.6M funding for Boosting our northern Australia Biosecurity frontline Out of Session. The Northern Australia Biosecurity funding currently comprises:

- \$16.9M Enhancing biosecurity outcomes
- \$17M Building regional resilience to manage biosecurity risks

- \$15M Building technical preparedness and response capability to a potential outbreak of lumpy skin disease
- \$12.7M Enhancing frontline biosecurity risk management.

The Reference Group will next meet in mid-2022.

The tenth meeting of the Northern Australia Biosecurity Framework Reference Group took place on Thursday 1 December 2021 by videoconference.

The Reference Group endorsed the draft Northern Australia Biosecurity Strategy (NABS) Implementation Plan, and noted next steps to progress the initiative would include:

- Develop measures to monitor the success of the Strategy.
- Develop a Communication Plan in respect to the Strategy.
- Explore funding avenues for appropriate investment for priority projects.
- Develop or identify Partnership Agreements with northern Australia industry and community.

The Reference Group also discussed:

- Development of a national biosecurity strategy
- Identification of assets of national biosecurity significance in Northern Australia
- Links to CSIRO priority projects in northern Australia

In addition, the Terms of Reference for the NABF Reference Group was updated to reflect a co-chairing arrangement between DAWE (Andrew Tongue) and NT DITT (Lorraine Corowa), and an extension for a further three years to support ongoing collaboration across northern Australia and the implementation of the Northern Australia Biosecurity Strategy.

The Reference Group will next meet in the second quarter of 2022.

The ninth meeting of the Northern Australia Biosecurity Framework Reference Group took place on Thursday 22 April 2021 in Darwin.

This was the first reference group meeting convened by new Chair Andrew Tongue, Deputy Secretary, Department of Agriculture, Water and the Environment. The Reference Group also welcomed the following new members:

- Lorraine Corowa from the Northern Territory Department of Industry, Tourism and Trade (replacing Amy Dennison),
- Colin Hunter, First Assistant Secretary, Biosecurity Operations Division (replacing Emily Canning),
- Chris Parker, First Assistant Secretary, Biosecurity Plant Division (replacing Marion Healey),
- Josephine Laduzko, Assistant Secretary, Biosecurity Strategy and Reform Office (replacing Matt Koval),
- Robyn Cleland, Chief Environmental Biosecurity Officer (replacing Ian Thompson).

The Reference Group discussed the shifting biosecurity risk profile of northern Australia as the north continues to develop. The Reference Group agreed to investigate a number of collaborative initiatives to strengthen biosecurity in northern Australia including:

- Working with industry partners to hold a biosecurity exercise for northern Australia
- Support for biosecurity Industry Liaison Officers for northern Australia.
- Opportunities for the use of existing defence technologies to support biosecurity surveillance efforts across northern Australia.

The Reference Group also received an update on the progress of an Implementation Plan for the Northern Australia Biosecurity Strategy which was endorsed by the Reference Group in May 2020. The Reference Group heard that Work Plans are being developed by the Northern Australia Animal, Plant and Aquatic Biosecurity Working Groups to identify priorities and timeframes for implementation of initiatives under the Strategy. The Implementation Plan will be considered by the Reference Group later this year.

Finally, the Reference Group considered mapping depicting current Indigenous Ranger group funding arrangements through various government programs across northern Australia and discussed opportunities to continue to work closely with Indigenous Rangers to conduct biosecurity surveillance in northern Australia.

The Reference Group will next meet by videoconference in August 2021 and again in person in November 2021.

The eighth meeting of the Northern Australia Biosecurity Framework Reference Group took place on Friday 6 March 2020 in Canberra at the office of the Department of Agriculture, Water and the Environment.

The Reference Group acknowledged the positive work of the Indigenous Ranger Biosecurity Program and requested the development of an overview of the Ranger national footprint, including government funding sources.

The Reference Group also considered biosecurity updates on a range of issues including the status of Fall Army Worm response and management plans and African swine fever preparedness, as well as biosecurity priorities in the context of the Agenda for the Northern Australia Strategic Partnership.

A focus of the meeting was to consider a draft of the Northern Australia Biosecurity Strategy and its linkages to industry and community. Jurisdictions agreed to sign a Memorandum of Understanding – a key element of the strategy – to foster a closer working relationship between the parties. The Reference Group also agreed there was a need for a working group to be established to identify initial strategy priorities, develop a stakeholder consultation plan and to help implement the strategy once agreed.

The Reference Group wished to express its thanks and appreciation to Marion Healy, First Assistant Secretary, Plant Biosecurity, Department of Agriculture, Water and the Environment, and Greg Fraser, Executive Director and Chief Executive Officer, Plant Health Australia. Both Marion and Greg will be retiring later in the year, and have contributed significantly to the work of the Reference Group.

The Reference Group will next meet in July 2020.

The seventh meeting of the Northern Australia Biosecurity Framework Reference Group took place on Friday 31 May 2019 in Brisbane at offices of the Department of Agriculture.

The group heard updates on a range of issues, including: opportunities to collaborate with the Cooperative Research Centre for Developing Northern Australia (CRCNA), the Post-Commencement Evaluation of the Developing Northern Australia White Paper, International Year of Plant Health 2020, the Indigenous Rangers Biosecurity Program, and the transition to business-as-usual of northern Australian biosecurity projects undertaken through the Agricultural Competitiveness White Paper.

The group also heard updates on northern biosecurity White Paper achievements, including: improvements to biosecurity practices within the peri-urban and non-English speaking communities in the Darwin region, the increased number of livestock disease surveillance investigations by private veterinarians in remote northern locations, and the recent detection of Asian Green Mussels on Mornington Island, which was a direct outcome of Indigenous ranger aquatic surveillance activities.

The group agreed to continue a number of high priority northern Australian surveillance activities post the Agricultural Competitiveness White Paper, which ceases on 30 June 2019. These included Industry Liaison Officers, continued engagement of non-English speaking growers across northern Australia, support for livestock disease surveillance and aquatic surveillance by Indigenous ranger groups.

The group agreed to the development of a Northern Australia Biosecurity Strategy to guide collaborative northern biosecurity efforts in the post-White Paper period. This will ensure key improvements to biosecurity delivered under the White Paper can be continued and built upon, to benefit farmers, communities and the environment across northern Australia.

The group acknowledged the efforts of the plant, animal and aquatic working groups, and agreed that they would continue to play an important role in the coordination of northern biosecurity activities, and the development of the Northern Australia Biosecurity Strategy.

The Reference Group will meet again in September 2019.

The sixth meeting of the Northern Australia Biosecurity Framework Reference Group took place in Perth on Thursday 1 November 2018 at the offices of the Western Australian Department of Primary Industries and Regional Development.

The Cooperative Research Centre for Developing Northern Australia (CRCNA) presented on its investment to-date in industry-led research, benefiting northern Australia. The Reference Group will work with the CRCNA to identify opportunities for greater collaboration on biosecurity-related projects.

The Reference Group were briefed on Agricultural Competitiveness White Paper projects and the significant improvements they are making to biosecurity in northern Australia.

With funding for White Paper projects and activities ceasing on 30 June 2019, the Reference Group agreed on biosecurity priorities post this period. This will ensure outcomes delivered under the White

Paper can be maintained and leveraged, leaving a legacy of benefits to farmers, communities and the environment across northern Australia.

The Reference Group also discussed opportunities for aligning biosecurity priorities with the work program being delivered by the Office of Northern Australia. This will provide additional support and continuity for biosecurity activities and investment post White Paper.

The Reference Group will meet again in March 2019.

The fifth meeting of the Northern Australia Biosecurity Framework Reference Group took place on Thursday 5 April 2018 on Gadigal land in Sydney.

The meeting heard updates on projects which benefit farmers, communities and the environment across northern Australia including:

- modern, more accurate and faster DNA/molecular technology that can be used in-the-field to detect whether insects are carrying diseases (eg. blue-tongue);
- new web-based and PC-based tools (eg. high resolution images and 'lucid keys') to help accurately identify exotic pests;
- new, smarter data technology including underwater aquatic pest monitoring in the Torres Strait and systems to collect and share biosecurity data across Australia;
- the release of the [Queensland Biosecurity Strategy 2018-2023](#);
- the successful eradication of banana freckle disease from NT;
- NT government work with animal, plant and aquatic industries to prepare for biosecurity emergencies;
- progress on the development of the new diagnostic laboratory in Darwin;
- work with Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander Ranger groups including aquatic biosecurity work in WA;
- the first joint meeting of national plant diagnostic and surveillance expert committees;
- collaboration with botanical gardens around Australia (including Cairns and Darwin) to manage biosecurity risks associated with up to 20million visitors each year;
- the extension of the Significant Disease Investigations Network to encourage vets across northern Australia to submit more samples of potential biosecurity diseases for diagnosis;
- work by plant, animal and aquatic Industry Liaison Officers to increase biosecurity awareness, surveillance and prevention practices;
- initiatives of the Office of Northern Australia, the Indigenous Reference Group and the Cooperative Research Centre for Developing Northern Australia which support agriculture and biosecurity;
- the availability of biosecurity information, including video and joint branding to promote biosecurity awareness across northern Australia.

The meeting was attended by senior representatives from Plant Health Australia, Animal Health Australia, Western Australian, Northern Territory and Queensland governments, the Office of Northern Australia and the Department of Agriculture and Water Resources.

The Reference Group is expected to meet again in the second half of 2018.

The fourth meeting of the Northern Australia Biosecurity Framework Reference Group met in Darwin on Friday 9 June 2017.

The Reference Group was welcomed by a Larakia biosecurity community liaison officer who shared her family's story of enduring connection with Country.

The Meeting heard reports on a range of projects to help agriculture and the general community prevent and manage biosecurity threats across northern Australia. Some of the recent achievements include:

- The number of additional Aboriginal and Torres Strait Islander ranger groups assisting with animal, plant and/or aquaculture work has increased to 28 (on top of 40 groups engaged prior to the Agricultural Competitiveness and Developing Northern Australia White Paper funding);
- Appointment of plant and aquaculture biosecurity liaison managers who will provide a vital communication link on practical biosecurity actions between producers, governments and the broader community;
- Pest and disease surveys of farms conducted jointly by industry and government scientists;
- Plans to trial underwater monitoring equipment in the Torres Strait and Cape York areas.

[Other examples of achievements](#) are available.

The Reference Group acknowledged the contribution of the industry/government technical working groups to tackle animal, plant and aquatic biosecurity problems and developing solutions together.

The Group welcomed the recent announcement by Minister Scullion of an additional \$30million for Indigenous Ranger compliance training.

The Group also made a commitment to pool ideas across organisations to produce targeted community-based information to promote active biosecurity engagement across northern Australia.

The Reference Group comprises senior representatives from NT, WA and Queensland governments, Animal Health Australia, Plant Health Australia, the Department of Prime Minister & Cabinet, the Office of Northern Australia and the Australian Department of Agriculture and Water Resources.

The Reference Group will meet again in late 2017.

The third meeting of the Northern Australia Biosecurity Framework Reference Group took place in Cairns on Tuesday 6 December 2016.

This meeting heard about progress on biosecurity projects which should benefit farmers, communities and the environment generally across northern Australia. Some of the main achievements in less than 12 months include:

- an additional 26 Indigenous Ranger groups have agreed to undertake biosecurity work across northern Australia, increasing number of ranger groups actively engaged in biosecurity work by over 50% and a total of sixty-six

- equipment and training has been provided to 57 ranger groups to increase the capacity of groups to deliver biosecurity work mainly in remote locations
- new ‘sentinel’ cattle herds have been established in Gunbalanya (NT), Merepah (Qld) and the Western Province of PNG to help monitor animal health in remote areas
- state, territory and commonwealth governments have agreed on the most important aquatic diseases and marine pests to be targeted across Northern Australia
- a network of tropical biosecurity diagnostic specialists has been established to link this expertise including animal health, entomology and plant pathology

The meeting endorsed a list of animal and plant surveillance projects to be managed cooperatively by governments and agriculture industry bodies.

All participants reported on the extensive range of biosecurity activities being undertaken and reinforced the importance of biosecurity across jurisdictions, industry groups and government departments.

These and other projects will build stronger, more secure biosecurity protection – not just for northern Australia but all of Australia.

The Reference Group agreed to bring forward an evaluation of the effectiveness of the Indigenous Ranger biosecurity initiative. This will help identify areas which should be improved, expanded and sustained into the future.

The Chief Executive Officer of the Torres Strait Regional Authority (TSRA), Mr Wayne See Kee, provided a comprehensive briefing of the role, challenges and opportunities for the TSRA and the Torres Strait community. The Meeting heard a report on a new Torres Strait/Cape York Biosecurity Working Group which met for the first time on 5 December 2016 to develop a more collaborative approach to biosecurity across the Torres Strait and Northern Cape York region. This Working group is a successful case study arising from a cooperative approach to biosecurity in priority areas of northern Australia.

The Reference Group also visited the Djunbunji Ranger group at East Trinity Reserve on Mandingalbay Yidinji Country who demonstrated a variety of biosecurity and environmental management work including acid sulphate rehabilitation, lychee and banana farming. For more information on the Djunbunji Ranger group visit, view the [Working Together for Yarrabah Biosecurity Film](#) produced by the Mandingalbay Yidinji Aboriginal Corporation.

The meeting was attended by senior representatives from WA, NT and Queensland governments, Plant Health Australia, Animal Health Australia, the Office of Northern Australia, the Department of Prime Minister & Cabinet, the Torres Strait Regional Authority and the Department of Agriculture and Water Resources.

The Reference Group will meet again in early 2017 in northern Australia.

The Northern Australia Biosecurity Framework Reference Group met on Wednesday 29 June 2016. The group discussions focused on collaborative biosecurity activities particularly around the

development of diagnostic capability and the potential scope of work for Indigenous Rangers in northern Australia.

Updates on priority areas:

Northern Australia Indigenous Rangers' initiative:

- 17 additional Ranger groups (on top of the existing 40 with whom the Australian Government have had contracts) agreeing to undertake biosecurity work across northern Australia.
- Procurement of training and equipment for Ranger groups to increase biosecurity operational capability and effectiveness is underway. Equipment includes utility terrain vehicles, trailers, computers and cameras, weed spraying units, water tanks, satellite phones and vehicle recovery kits.

'Stronger Biosecurity services in northern Australia' initiative:

- The establishment of three additional sentinel herds to increase northern Australia's arbovirus vigilance – two were established in northern Australia and one in PNG. A fourth additional sentinel herd will be established in Timor-Leste, with a scoping visit to Timor-Leste to be delivered in June in partnership with Berrimah Veterinary Laboratory.
- The establishment of a surveillance technical working group to develop, prioritise and coordinate the delivery of initiatives to improve biosecurity in northern Australia. The group is an operational working group with key outcomes to improve plant and animal investigation through training and developing capacity and ensuring priority pests and diseases are those that have significant impact in the north.

'Better diagnostic capacity' initiative:

- The establishment of a Tropical Plant Biosecurity Diagnostics Network to link diagnostician's skills with modern diagnostic tools across northern Australia.
- Investment in new diagnostic equipment in northern laboratories to support tropical biosecurity surveillance and response needs. This has included a scanning electron microscope, culture incubators, dissecting microscopes and thermal cyclers.

The Reference Group was chaired by Department of Agriculture and Water Resources Deputy Secretary Lyn O'Connell and was attended by:

- Jim Thompson, Queensland Chief Biosecurity Officer;
- Michelle Rodan, NT Director Biosecurity and Animal Welfare;
- Kevin Chennell, Executive Director Biosecurity and Regulation Department of Agriculture & Food WA;
- Kathleen Plowman, Chief Executive Officer - Animal Health Australia,
- Mark Coffey, Head of Office of Northern Australia;
- Kim Ritman, Chief Plant Protection Officer;
- Mark Schipp, Chief Veterinary Officer, Department of Agriculture and Water Resources.

The Reference Group will meet again in northern Australia in October 2016.

The inaugural Northern Australia Biosecurity Framework Reference Group met on Wednesday 23 March 2016.

The Reference Group was established to strengthen biosecurity across northern Australia and support a collaborative approach to new northern Australia biosecurity projects.

The group noted the intent of the Developing Northern Australia and the Agricultural Competitiveness White Papers, including increasing economic opportunities and stronger agriculture in particular.

The Reference Group discussed opportunities presented by the White Papers to deliver lasting benefits in six areas:

- Indigenous Rangers – expanding the scope, volume and remuneration of biosecurity work undertaken by Indigenous biosecurity rangers across northern Australia;
- Northern Australia Biosecurity Surveillance – including new aquatic biosecurity surveillance work and improving biosecurity infrastructure on Torres Strait Islands;
- Offshore Biosecurity Surveillance – including collaborative biosecurity surveys in Indian Ocean territories and neighbouring countries;
- Modern diagnostics– to support tropical biosecurity networks, knowledge and facilities;
- Better data – to improve the accuracy and usefulness of field biosecurity data collected across northern Australia; and
- Community engagement – expanding information and tools available to identify and report potential biosecurity threats.

The Reference Group was chaired by Department of Agriculture and Water Resources Deputy Secretary Ms Lyn O'Connell and was attended by:

- Jim Thompson, Queensland Chief Biosecurity Officer;
- Michelle Rodan, NT Director Biosecurity and Animal Welfare;
- Kevin Chennell, Executive Director Biosecurity and Regulation Department of Agriculture & Food WA;
- Greg Fraser, CEO Plant Health Australia;
- Ian Langstaff, Animal Health Australia,
- Mark Coffey, Head of Office of Northern Australia;
- Brant Smith, Department of Prime Minister & Cabinet;
- Kim Ritman, Chief Plant Protection Officer;
- Robyn Martin, Animal Biosecurity Division, Department of Agriculture and Water Resources.

The Reference Group will meet again in Darwin in May.